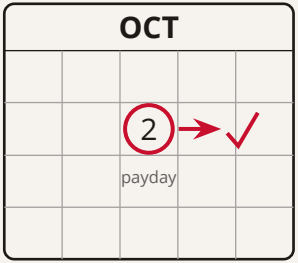
Kept

Promises customers can keep: one guarded action, dated after payday, released by a person.



Team Sharpe Shooters
CIBC Collections Hackathon · 16 October 2026

THE PROBLEM

Collections today asks for money on the wrong day

- **Five systems, five keys per person.** Each files the same customer differently, so nobody sees the whole person.
- **Promises are dated by the calendar, not by pay.** A promise due before payday breaks; the bank's own data shows promised money paid is **+6.1 pts** higher when the due date falls just after payday.
- **More contact doesn't help.** The bank's randomised champion, two challengers and a hold-out keep promises at the same rate.
- **Hardship gets missed** in notes and calls, so vulnerable customers are pushed like anyone.

96,000
open cases tonight

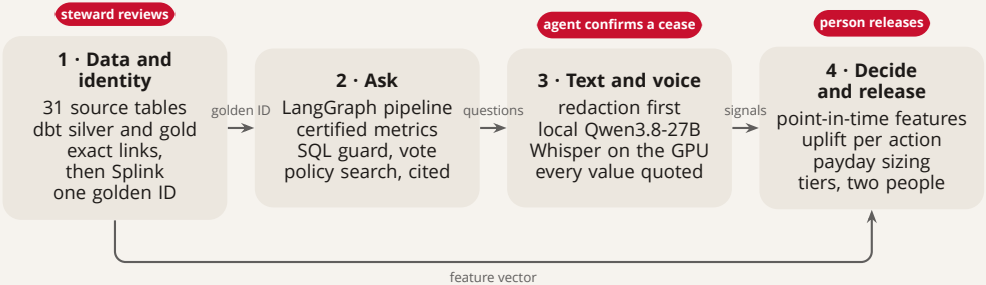
$68.7M
balance at risk

38,115
need a hardship specialist

Source: evidence.md §1–2; tonight's nba.cards

SYSTEM DESIGN

Four layers, one guarded decision



Nightly: dbt build → features → score 96,000 cards (~85 s). Live: the API rechecks every release on fresh data.

Source: src/kept/cli.py (nightly), docs/design/SharpeShooters_SystemDesign.pdf

ARCHITECTURE

A small stack that maps onto a bank's

Piece	Here	At the bank
Warehouse	DuckDB file, dbt silver/gold, Feast online store	the bank's lakehouse; dbt models carry over
Audit	DuckDB, append-only, SHA-256 chain, `kept audit-verify`	WORM storage, same chain
Models	LightGBM uplift + promise, MLflow, champion/challenger gate	model risk management sign-off
Local language models	Qwen3.8-27B on llama.cpp, Whisper, bge-m3 on one machine	an on-prem inference cluster
The Ask's model	the same local Qwen3.8-27B: no hosted API, no keys	the bank's approved model
API and app	FastAPI; Next.js workspace; personas	SSO, the bank's design system

Speed: 96,000 cards in ~85 s; portfolio overview ~40 ms; audit page 7.9 s → 0.04 s after moving filters into SQL. 1,322 tests; every change through CI.

Source: README.md, pyproject.toml, web/package.json

LAYER 1 · DATA AND IDENTITY

Five keys become one person, and a steward checks the doubtful ones

- **Exact links first** (shared account and customer numbers), **then probabilistic matching** (Splink, names, dates of birth, addresses) for the rest.
- **Uncertain pairs go to a person**: 36,279 wait in the steward queue, oldest first, before two records ever merge.
- **Data quality is a contract**: 31 tables checked on load (types, ranges, duplicates), issues reported, not hidden.

99%
of 200 injected duplicates found

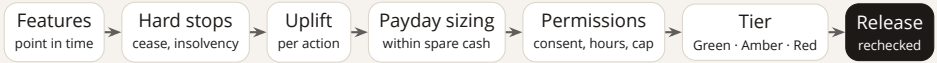
0
wrong merges

36,279
pairs for a steward, paged

Source: docs/reports/identity_recall.md, QUALITY_REPORT.pdf

LAYER 4 · DECIDE AND RELEASE

From a feature vector to a released action, in seven checked steps



Uplift, not propensity

LightGBM T-learner: one model per action against waiting. Contact whoever a contact changes, not whoever pays anyway.

Dated after payday

Next payday rolled forward from deposits or asked on the pay page; the promise falls due 1–2 days after, inside spare cash.

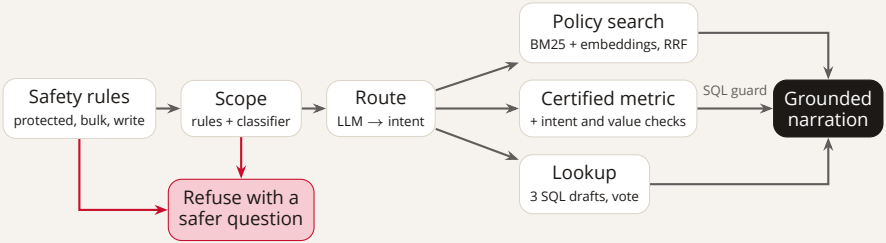
People release

Green in a sampled team-lead batch; Amber by the agent; Red by a hardship specialist and a second person. Every release rechecks on fresh data.

Source: src/kept/nba/engine.py, src/kept/nba/release.py

LAYER 2 · THE ASK, AS A LANGGRAPH

Every answer walks a graph, and shows the path it took



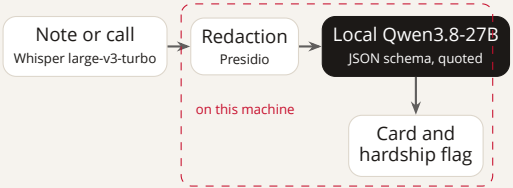
Every number in an answer must appear in the rows it came from; the SQL guard allows read-only queries on approved tables and columns only; the trace (*Route: metric · SQL guard: allowed · 1 row*) shows under each answer.

On the local model: released 21/21 · stress suite 38/42 · unseen drill 27/30. Two deterministic checks fix what the router can slip on: a channel the question names, a value the warehouse stores differently.

Source: src/kept/ask/graph.py, docs/reports/ask_accuracy.md

LAYER 3 · TEXT AND VOICE

Hardship heard the first time, without the words leaving the machine



- Every extracted value carries the exact quote it rests on; agents confirm a cease before it stops contact.
- Replies are decoded to the JSON schema: malformed replies went from 152 of 1,172 calls to 0.

1.00
hardship recall, notes and calls

9.4%
word errors (bank's speech-to-text: 12.4%)

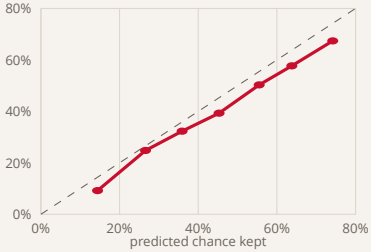
≥0.80
F1 on every extracted field

Source: docs/reports/extraction_gate.md, voice_wer.md

EXPLAINABILITY

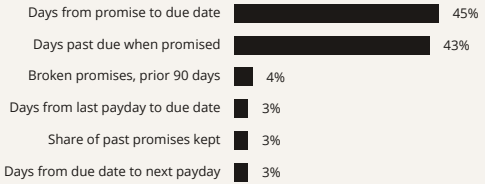
Every card says why, and the models say how far to trust them

Promise model: is a 60% promise kept 60% of the time?



AUC 0.610, Brier 0.221 on 50,653 promises it never saw (isotonic calibration). Dashed: perfect.

What drives it (share of |TreeSHAP|)



Per card: the 12 largest TreeSHAP contributions, both directions, on the case page. Uplift model: Qini 0.0008 ± 0.0005 on 141,350 held-out decisions.

Source: data/exports/reports/model_card.json (scripts/model_card.py)

DECISIONS, AND THE ALTERNATIVE WE REJECTED

Why it's built this way

We chose	Instead of	Because
Uplift per action	a propensity-to-pay score	propensity contacts people who'd pay anyway; uplift finds who a contact changes
Timing (payday)	more channels or intensity	the bank's A/B: strategies keep promises at the same rate; payday timing adds +6.1 pts
Local models for everything	a hosted model	customer words never leave the bank; no per-call cost; no quota or outage mid-demo
Certified metrics first	free-form SQL from a model	reviewed definitions answer most questions with no model-written SQL
A graph with checks (LangGraph)	one prompt	each step is testable, traced, and fixable without retuning a prompt
Two people for Red	one approver or the model	hardship decisions are never one person's or a model's
Schema-constrained decoding	parse-and-retry	malformed replies 152 → 0 of 1,172 calls
Qwen3.8-27B on llama.cpp	Gemma 3 12B on Ollama	Ollama ran a 4k window under a 9k prompt; released 18 → 21/21

Source: docs/reports/evidence.md, extraction_gate.md; the portfolio's A/B panel

RIGOUR

What we tried, measured, and didn't ship

A bigger local model

Gemma 4 26B on a 16 GB GPU: 24 s a note against 3 s, runaway replies, no better on held-out notes. Rejected; the dense Qwen3.8-27B fits and is faster.

A tuned uplift model

40 candidates tuned on a validation window; the best lost to the champion on held-out decisions (Qini 0.0029 vs 0.0073). X- and DR-learners won some arms and lost others. The gate kept the champion.

A leaky feature

amount_ratio made AUC 0.92: it encoded the outcome. Dropped; honest AUC 0.63. A wider model then matched the bank's (0.697 vs 0.702); averaged with it, 0.764.

The rule: a change ships only if it beats what's live by more than the noise, on data it never saw.

SAFE BY CONSTRUCTION

Checked every night, not promised once

0 / 96,000
cards change when every protected attribute is scrambled and the book rescored

0.87–1.00
contact ratio across 11 protected attributes; a minimum-events rule

1 chain
every recommendation, release and override hash-chained; one edit breaks it

1 switch
reverts everyone to the bank's strategy; a worse model can't go live

- **Roles:** agents see their own cases; analysts see aggregates only (groups under 10 suppressed, no single case); names masked for every role but compliance.
- **Drift:** 8 features drift, 5 to watch, 13 stable (PSI vs training); 1 payroll features never appear in training rows. Drift on a model input pauses promotion until a retrain is checked.
- **Voice biometrics, accent and pitch are never inputs**; accent is used only to check Whisper works equally well (9.1–10.1% across regions).

Source: docs/reports/fairness_report.pdf, separated_review.md, drift_report.pdf; kept audit-verify

ONE CUSTOMER

Meet Jane: her last promise fell due before payday, and broke

- Pay lands in 3 days and is down 27% on her average.
- She answers calls after 18:00, not in the morning slot the strategy uses.
- Her notes say her shifts were cut: a hardship signal nobody acted on.

Kept's card for Jane

Call, Tue 18:00–20:00
$140 a month × 3, due the day after payday, inside ~$160 spare cash

Why: pay lands in 3 days (+9 pts) · pay down 27% (+6) · answers after 18:00 (+4)

Red hardship: a specialist and a second person release it

Source: the guided demo (case CS-2026-118204)

THE PRODUCT

One workspace for every role

Queue and case
ranked by expected recovery; a cited case brief from the local model; the full "why"; contacts, promises and month-ends from the warehouse

Portfolio
tonight's book, the A/B as a forest plot, cohorts, insights with their SQL, models, fairness and drift

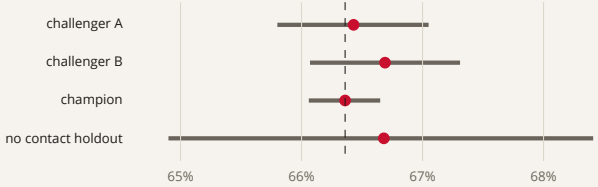
Ask, approvals, audit
plain-English questions with traced paths and sources; stage-by-stage release; the hash-chained trail

Notifications come from the audit log (nothing stored twice); the customer's pay page asks for payday when the bank doesn't know it (about 3 customers in 4).

MEASURED IMPACT

The bank's own randomised test: strategy doesn't move promises, timing does

Promise-kept rate by strategy (95% Wilson interval)



Every interval overlaps the champion's (dashed).

+6.1 pts

promised money paid when due 0–2 days after payday (95% CI 2.8–10.6), 12,808 promises in randomised cases

+61 per 1,000

more customers paying within 14 days when Kept chooses the action, paired on the same decisions (95% CI 55–67; off-policy, doubly robust)

Source: silver.collections_cases (closed, randomised); evidence.md §1–2, §4

IS IT REAL?

Every claim, its test, its 95% interval

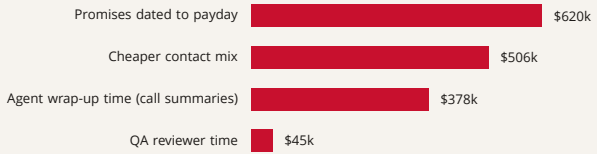
Claim	Test	Result [95% CI]	
Payday dating raises money paid	randomised cases	+6.1 pts [2.8–10.6]	holds
It is the payday, not the customer	vs 1–3 days either side	+7.7 [5.0–9.8] · +8.3 [6.1–10.5]	holds
Same customer, on vs off payday	fixed effects	+4.0 pts [1.1–7.4]	holds
Fake paydays show nothing	paydays moved 3–10 days	6 of 6 intervals include 0	holds
Promise model vs the bank's	paired bootstrap	0.697 vs 0.702 [-1.9 to +1.0]	tie
The two models together	rank average, nothing fitted	0.764, +6.1 [5.1–6.9]	holds
Kept's action vs the bank's	doubly robust, paired	+61 payers / 1,000 [55–67]	holds
Targeting by uplift	randomised cells only	$+18K to $+42K / 1,000, CI spans 0	unproven
Pays back in year one	20,000 simulated draws	99.97% (98.5% if correlated)	holds

Source: evidence.md §2, §2a, §4, §8, §9; business_case.pdf

BUSINESS VALUE

$1.55M a year in the base case, and where it comes from

Base case by driver ($k a year)



Payday dating: more promised money paid on the promises made each year. Contact mix: fewer calls, more payment links. Wrap-up: call summaries agents don't type. QA: reviewers check flagged calls only.

$1.55M
a year, base case (low $0.44M, high $4.27M)

2.4×
year-one ROI, base case

2.6 months
payback, base case

99.97% of 20,000 draws over every assumption pay back in year one (98.5% if they all move together). With no payday effect it still pays back; with everything else at its low end it needs 0.2 pts.

Source: docs/reports/business_case.pdf, data/exports/reports/business_data.json

VALUE BEYOND DOLLARS

What the customer and the regulator get

Guard (must not get worse)	Bank today	Kept
Contact-cap breaches	0.03% of cases	0 (checked at release)
Contact outside calling hours	1.4% of cases	0
Hardship notes missed	not measured	recall 1.00
Any-contact fairness ratio	not measured	0.87 or above
Complaints	3.1% of cases	needs a live pilot cell

Every action is explained (fixed sentences, never model text), on the record, and released by a named person.

NEXT

A pilot that proves it, with a rule that ends it either way

- **20% hold-out first**: the payday effect shows within 2 weeks (80% power); then a permanent 5% on the bank's strategy (7 weeks to the same answer).
- **A randomised due-date cell**, so the payday effect becomes a trial, not an estimate.
- **Primary metric:** promised money paid. **Guards:** complaints, caps, hours, fairness ratio.

Decision rule

Stop early for harm if any guard worsens beyond its 95% interval; scale up if promised money paid beats the hold-out's interval for two consecutive months; otherwise run to the planned size.

Day one

kill switch, nightly drift and fairness checks, the audit chain, and payday asked where the bank doesn't know it.

HOW WE BUILT IT

Four tracks, gated, every number reproducible

- Data · Ask · Text and GPU · Decisions, integrated at gates G0–G4.
- 170+ pull requests, each through CI; 1,322 tests.
- Local models only: no hosted API and no keys; nothing leaves the machine.
- `JUDGES.md`: every claim, its report, and the command that reproduces it.

Reproduce any number

```
uv run kept nightly
uv run python scripts/evidence_report.py
uv run python scripts/model_card.py
uv run python scripts/bench_run.py ...

bash scripts/secret_scan.sh
```

Jane’s promise lands the day after payday, inside what she can spare, and her hardship was heard the first time she said it.

APPENDIX

Who can see and do what

Role	Sees	Names	Releases	Ask
Collections agent	own cases	masked	Amber on own cases	yes
Hardship specialist	every case	masked	Red, first approval	yes
Team lead	every case	masked	Red second; Green batch	yes
Compliance	every case and the full trail	unmasked	Red second	yes
Analyst	aggregates only (groups ≥ 10)	none	none	yes
Data steward	match pairs	masked	merge or split	yes

Source: src/kept/governance/access.py, src/kept/web/src/lib/session.ts

APPENDIX

The Ask's benchmarks, on the local model

21/21
the organisers' released questions with dev gold

38/42
our stress suite, aimed at the release's traps

27/30
an unseen drill we never tuned on (one question in French)

- Every model call is local (Qwen3.8-27B on llama.cpp): no hosted API, no keys, no quota. The graph's deterministic checks (channel, stored values, column repair, dates, cohorts, relevance, "can we" means policy) and a convention linter keep the model on the rails; drafts that disagree escalate to five, then the model judges the results.
- A refusal must refuse; a number must match gold within the stated tolerance; a policy answer must cite the section.

Source: data/exports/reports/{released,stress,drill}_answers.json; docs/reports/ask_accuracy.md

APPENDIX

The uplift search we ran, and why the champion stayed

Model, on held-out decisions	Qini, calls	noise	Qini, any contact
Champion (live)	0.0073	0.0003	0.0008
Tuned challenger	0.0029	0.0003	-0.0006

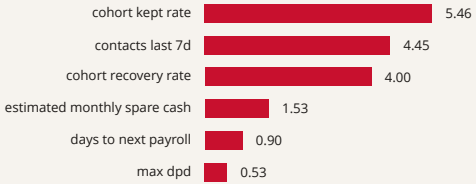
40 candidates were compared on a validation window inside the training period (15 Jul to 15 Aug); only the best was judged once on the test decisions, by the nightly's own gate. It lost beyond noise, so the champion stays.

Source: docs/reports/tuning.md (scripts/tune_uplift.py)

APPENDIX

Drift and fairness, in detail

Largest population shifts (PSI, live vs training)



Above 0.25 is drift. The promise-kept rate fell from about 63% to 35% in 2026, so cohort rates moved most; drift on a model input pauses promotion.

Fairness flags (four-fifths rule, ratio under 0.80)

gender code, call: 0.72; marital status, call: 0.73; marital status, hardship review: 0.76.

Each is reviewed: small groups, or explained by recorded hardship. Protected attributes are never model inputs, and scrambling them changes 0 of 96,000 cards.

Source: data/exports/reports/drift_data.json, fairness_data.json